Q+A

QUEEN OF CRIME

Oscar-winning film producer **Guneet Monga's** thriller series *Gyaarah Gyaarah* releases on the OTT platform ZEE5 on August 9



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Q. *Gyaarah Gyaarah* is an official adaptation of the hit K-drama *Signal*. What drew you to it?
It blew us away. We worked very hard to get the official adaptation rights. We wanted the audience [here] to experience it individually and at a scale and see how the show is grounded to India. What happens when a walkie-talkie misconnection happens between two cops in two different timelines and a butterfly effect starts.

Q. You and Karan Johar produced the series as well the recently-released violent action film *Kill*. How did the collaboration happen?
We have always been talking about it since [the 2013 release] *The Lunchbox* [co-produced by Monga's Sikhya Entertainment and distributed by Johar's Dharma Productions]. I wanted to find a project that I could take to him. He heard the first half of *Kill* and said 'I am on'. There is only one word that describes [our partnership]–empowering.

Q. You've won recognition as an independent producer who has taken Indian cinema to international film festivals. How do you see this year given the wins at Sundance [*Girls Will be Girls*] and Cannes [*All We Imagine as Light*].
The overall goal is to celebrate Indian cinema. All these [films] are adding to that ultimate dream. I can't be the only one doing this. It's incredible if more people win big awards and more of us collaborate and penetrate and make more contacts, it will only add to the overall conversation.

Q. After winning the Oscar for *The Elephant Whisperers*, do you feel the pressure to deliver something of that benchmark?
I don't take the pressure. I actually do everything with the same love, gusto and sense of wonder. I want to keep that alive. I still physically jump in office if I see something nice. It was the same when I saw the first two episodes of *Gyaarah Gyaarah*.

–with Suhani Singh